

Exam 3 Study Guide: Mill and Nozick on Happiness and Value

I. Key Definitions and Concepts

1. The Greatest Happiness Principle (Mill)

- The foundation of utilitarian ethics: actions are *right* if they promote happiness, *wrong* if they produce the opposite.
- “Happiness” = pleasure and the absence of pain; “unhappiness” = pain and privation of pleasure.
- Moral value is judged by the *consequences* of actions for overall happiness — not personal gain or intention.

2. Higher and Lower Pleasures (Mill)

- Not all pleasures are equal in value.
- *Higher pleasures* engage our “higher faculties” (e.g., intellect, imagination, moral sentiments).
- *Lower pleasures* are bodily or base pleasures shared with animals.
- Mill: “It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied.”
- The worth of pleasures depends on quality as well as quantity.

3. Competent Judges (Mill)

- Those who have experienced both higher and lower pleasures are best qualified to judge their relative value.
- Competent judges consistently prefer pleasures that engage higher faculties, even if they bring more dissatisfaction.
- Their verdict determines which pleasures are “higher” in quality.

4. Experience Machine (Nozick)

- A thought experiment: Would you plug into a machine that could simulate any pleasurable life you want?
- Most people say no — suggesting we value *more than pleasure*, such as *reality*, *truth*, *authenticity*, and *connection to others*.
- Aimed at refuting hedonism (the view that only pleasure matters).

5. Reality Principle (Freud and Nozick)

- **Freud's reality principle:** We sometimes delay pleasure or endure pain for greater, more secure pleasure later.
- **Nozick's "second reality principle":** Reality and truth themselves are intrinsically valuable — not merely useful for achieving pleasure.

II. Key Arguments and Themes

Mill: The Structure of Utilitarianism

- **Ultimate moral standard:** The Greatest Happiness Principle.
- **Universal focus:** The happiness that matters is not one's own, but everyone's.
 1. "As between his own happiness and that of others, utilitarianism requires him to be strictly impartial."
- **Quality vs. Quantity:** Higher pleasures are "more desirable and more valuable" because they involve our rational and moral capacities.
- **Proof of the principle:**
 1. Only proof that something is desirable = people actually desire it.
 2. Everyone desires happiness → happiness is good for each person → general happiness is good for all.
- **Virtue and happiness:** Virtue can become part of happiness itself — not a rival to it.
- **Common objections and Mill's responses:**
 1. "*It's a doctrine fit for swine.*" → Humans have higher faculties.

2. *"It's too demanding."* → The standard is the rule of action, not the motive.
3. *"It's godless or expedient."* → It aligns with the Golden Rule and moral impartiality.

Nozick: Beyond Pleasure and Happiness

- **Challenge to hedonism:** Happiness is not the only thing that matters.
- **Narrative and direction:** We care about *the shape of our lives* — upward or downward trajectories of happiness, not just total amount.
- **Depth and meaning:** A life of "bovine contentment" lacks depth; we'd trade some pleasure for meaningful experience.
- **Reality and connection:**
 - We want our experiences to be *true* and *connected to the real world*.
 - The experience machine shows we care about *being*, not just *feeling*.
- **Three kinds of happiness (as emotions):**
 - Being happy *that* something is the case (episodic joy).
 - Feeling that *your life is good now* (contentment in the present).
 - *Satisfaction with one's life as a whole* (reflective happiness).
- **Happiness as mood/disposition:**
 - A *mood* = a temporary evaluative tendency (seeing things positively).
 - A *disposition* = a more stable tendency to experience happiness over time.
- **Upward-sloping lives:** We value improvement and progress — not just static pleasure.
- **Conclusion:** Happiness is valuable and wonderful, but not all that matters. We also seek truth, reality, connection, virtue, and meaning.

III. Comparison: Mill vs. Nozick

Theme

Mill

Nozick

What is happiness?	Pleasure and absence of pain	A set of emotions, moods, and evaluations about life
Value of pleasure	Intrinsic good; some pleasures higher than others	Valuable, but not the only good; happiness alone cannot define a good life
Quality of life	Measured by the kind of pleasures we pursue	Measured by reality, authenticity, and meaningful connection
Role of reality	Not discussed explicitly	Central — we value <i>real</i> connection, not mere experience
Main goal of ethics	Promote the greatest happiness for all	Seek a life that is good and real, not just happy
Relation to hedonism	Refines it (qualitative utilitarianism)	Critiques and rejects it (anti-hedonist)

IV. Study Questions and Review Prompts

Use these to prepare for short-answer and essay sections:

1. How does Mill define happiness, and why does he think its promotion should be the basis of morality?
2. Why does Mill think some pleasures are “higher” than others? How does he justify this claim?
3. How does Mill respond to critics who call utilitarianism selfish or overly demanding?
4. What is Nozick’s *experience machine* meant to prove? What does our likely refusal to plug in suggest?
5. How does Nozick’s “second reality principle” expand our understanding of what makes life valuable?
6. How do Mill and Nozick each connect happiness with the use of human reason or higher faculties?

7. How might Nozick's view about the structure of a "good life" (narrative, reality, depth) respond to Mill's utilitarianism?
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V. Suggested Focus for Review

- Be able to **define** key terms clearly and concisely.
 - Understand **Mill's arguments for qualitative utilitarianism** and **Nozick's critique of hedonism**.
 - Practice explaining **why Nozick's experience machine challenges the utilitarian view** that pleasure is the only intrinsic good.
 - Reflect on **what each philosopher believes makes life truly good or worth living**.
 - Be ready to **compare** the two thinkers: Mill refines hedonism into a moral philosophy; Nozick dismantles it by showing the value of reality, truth, and meaning.
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